Content brief template: a 10-part SEO brief

One brief = one piece = one URL. The client fills in parts 1–5 before talking to the writer, parts 6–9 you complete together, and part 10 is for reviewing the draft. Version: November 2026.

Piece (working title) _____ Brief date _____

Brief written by _____ Brief version _____

How to use this template

1. **Pick the keyword and the URL:** check Search Console (Performance → filter by query → Pages tab) to see whether another page of yours already shows up for that keyword.
2. **Review Google's results** in a private window: the top five, the AI Overview and related questions. Record them in part 4.
3. **Add what the piece will contribute** (part 5) and build the outline (part 6). Approve the outline before writing starts.
4. **Review the draft with the checklist** (part 10): write comments next to the check number.

1 Assignment

The basics: what is being written, where it will go live and when.

Content type: ☐ how-to article ☐ service page ☐ category or product page ☐ comparison ☐ update to an existing piece

Target URL (new or existing) _____

Client, point of contact _____ Email, phone _____

Writer _____ Revisions included _____

Outline due _____ Draft due _____

Publication date _____ Length (range from top 5) _____

2 Goal and audience

Why the piece exists and who it speaks to. One sentence is enough for the goal if it's specific.

Business goal: what the reader should do next (inquiry, call, sign-up, visit the service page)

_____

Main call to action (CTA) and the page it leads to _____

Audience: who they are, what they already know, what problem they want to solve

_____

_____

Stage: ☐ looking for information ☐ comparing options ☐ ready to buy

Customer questions and objections (from calls, emails and sales conversations)

_____

_____

3 Primary keyword and search intent

One group of keywords with the same intent means one URL. Give search volume with its source and date; don't guess.

Primary keyword _____ Searches / month, source, date _____

Secondary keywords and variants (same intent only)

Intent: ☐ informational ☐ commercial ☐ transactional ☐ navigational

Format that wins in the results: ☐ guide ☐ list ☐ comparison ☐ service page ☐ template or tool

Out of scope (topics and keywords assigned to other URLs on your site)

4 SERP analysis: top 5 and AI Overview

Search the keyword on Google in a private window and open the top five organic results (no ads). Date checked: _____

POS.	URL	TYPE AND FORMAT	WHAT IT COVERS	WHAT IT MISSES
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				

Must-cover topics (what every page in the top 5 covers)

AI Overview: ☐ shown ☐ not shown

Which question the AI Overview answers and which pages it cites

People also ask and search box suggestions

5 What we add (information gain) and materials

At least one thing the top 10 results don't have. Real data only, the kind that can be checked.

What we bring: ☐ our own data ☐ a real example ☐ prices or price ranges ☐ photos of our work ☐ an expert's view ☐ a table, checklist or calculator

What exactly, and where it comes from

MATERIAL FROM THE BUSINESS	WHO PROVIDES IT	BY WHEN

Expert to interview or review (name, role)

6 Outline

Approve the outline before writing starts: it's the cheapest moment to make changes. Every heading answers a reader's question.

H1 (suggested, with the primary keyword)

Opening paragraph: which question it answers directly (40–60 words)

LEVEL	HEADING	QUESTION IT ANSWERS	MUST INCLUDE (FACTS, EXAMPLES)
H2			

Questions for the FAQ section (3–6)

7 Links and sources

Link to the parent page and to 2–4 related pages. The link text describes the target page (“website brief template”, not “click here”).

LINK TO (URL)	LINK TEXT (ANCHOR)	WHERE IN THE PIECE

Pages that should link to the new piece after publication

Sources for facts and figures (URL and date checked)

8 Tone, style and rules

Voice: ☐ second person (you) ☐ formal ☐ impersonal

Reader’s level: ☐ beginner ☐ intermediate ☐ expert

Required words and names (services, brand)

Banned words and phrases

A piece whose style we like (URL)

AI: ☐ not used ☐ research and outline only ☐ draft allowed, every fact checked by hand

> Google doesn’t ban AI-assisted content, but it says facts should be checked by hand, including the title, meta description and image alt text. Generating many pages without value for readers breaks its spam policies.

9 Metadata and author

Google sets no length limit but truncates titles and descriptions in results. Our audit flags titles over 60 characters and descriptions over 160.

Title: unique, primary keyword first (characters: ____)

Meta description: a summary and a reason to click (120–160 characters; characters: ____)

URL: short, with the keyword’s words, no dates

Image alt text: describe the image, no keyword stuffing

Author (byline, short bio)

Expert reviewer (YMYL)

Publication date

Next review

10 Draft review checklist

Mark each check OK or needs work. Write comments next to the check number so the writer knows what they refer to.

NO.	CHECK	STATUS	COMMENTS
1	The piece matches the search intent and covers the must-cover topics from part 4	☐ OK ☐ needs work	
2	The opening paragraph answers the main question directly	☐ OK ☐ needs work	
3	It includes what part 5 promised (data, example, photos, expert)	☐ OK ☐ needs work	
4	One H1, and the H2 and H3 headings follow the outline or the changes were agreed	☐ OK ☐ needs work	
5	The primary keyword is in the title, the H1 and the opening paragraph, and reads naturally elsewhere, with no forced repetition	☐ OK ☐ needs work	
6	Facts, figures and prices are checked at the source, and the sources are cited	☐ OK ☐ needs work	
7	The piece doesn't target keywords assigned to other URLs (part 3)	☐ OK ☐ needs work	
8	Internal links with descriptive anchor text are added in both directions	☐ OK ☐ needs work	
9	The title and meta description are ready and unique	☐ OK ☐ needs work	
10	Images have alt text and descriptive file names, and are compressed	☐ OK ☐ needs work	
11	The author is credited, and on YMYL topics the expert review is stated on the page	☐ OK ☐ needs work	
12	The piece is proofread, with no placeholders or editing notes left in	☐ OK ☐ needs work	
13	After publication: the URL is in the sitemap and checked in Search Console (URL Inspection)	☐ OK ☐ needs work	

Results after publication (Search Console → Performance, page filter)

AFTER	CLICKS	IMPRESSIONS	AVG. POSITION	TOP QUERIES (MATCH PART 3?)
30 days				
90 days				

Draft reviewed by _____ Review date _____